

LESSON 1: OVERVIEW OF THE DEVELOPMENT IN THE STUDY OF PHILOSOPHY AND ETHICS

What is Ethics?

- Ethics is the branch of philosophy that deals with questions about what is **morally right and wrong, good and bad, fair and unfair**.
- It involves the **systematic examination** of how people should act and what principles should guide their behavior.
- Ethics explores the nature of **moral values, duties, and responsibilities**, and seeks to establish standards for evaluating human actions.

Ethics as a Branch of Philosophy

The term **philosophy** comes from two Greek words: "**philo**" (love) and "**sophia**" (wisdom) → "**Love of Wisdom**."

Three Major Epochs

- Cosmocentric Epoch** (Ancient) – Focus is to study the origin/the "primordial stuff" of the universe.
- Theocentric Epoch** (Medieval) – Focus is to know what/who controls everything, or whether there is God or no God.
- Anthropocentric Epoch** (Modern) – Focus directed toward man himself: "How should I behave with others?" — centered on man.

Ethics is the Practical Science of the Morality of Human Conduct

A. Ethics is a science.

A science is a **relatively complete and systematically arranged body** of connected data together with the **causes or reasons by which these data are known to be true**.

B. Ethics is a science of human conduct.

- Human acts** – a deliberate and free act, performed with advertence and motive; an act determined (chosen and given existence) by **free will**.
- Acts of man** – acts performed by human beings without advertence, or without the exercise of free choices.

Human Acts versus Acts of Man

Human Acts	Acts of Man
Done consciously and freely by the agent/man	Beyond one's consciousness; not dependent on intellect & will
1. Knowledge of the act 2. Freedom 3. Voluntariness	1. Done without knowledge 2. Without consent 3. Involuntary

- Human conduct is free, knowing, deliberate human activity.
- The relation of human activity with the dictates of reason is called **MORALITY**.
- Ethics deals with the morality of human conduct.
- ETHICS** – from Greek "**ethos**": "a characteristic way of acting."
- MORALITY** – from Latin "**mos, moris**": "character, behavior, morals, custom, or habit."

Morality and Ethics (M. Velasquez)

- Morality** pertains to standards of right and wrong, usually inherited from a community.
- Ethics** studies standards of right and wrong, the act of making a decision, the nature of the agent who makes the decision.

The Study of Ethics

- Ethics entails a reflective distance to critically examine standards.
- It looks at the agent who makes the moral decision.
- It is about the moral decision-making process.

Branches of Moral Philosophy

- Meta-Ethics** – theoretical meaning/reference of moral propositions and how truth values are determined. (*What is morality? What is justice? Is there truth?*)
- Normative Ethics** – practical means of determining a moral course of action. (*What we ought to do?*)
- Applied Ethics** – what a person is obligated/permitted to do in a special situation (war, animal rights, capital punishment). (*Should we lie to help a friend?*)

Importance of Ethics

- It satisfies basic human needs.
- It creates credibility.
- It unites people and leaders.
- It improves decision-making.
- It secures the society.

Why Should Students Study Ethics?

- Allows you to live an authentic and meaningful life.
- Makes you more successful.
- Allows you to cultivate inner peace.
- Provides for a stable society.
- May help out in the afterlife.

Postulates in Ethics

Postulates are proven facts that need to be presupposed (e.g., Theory of Relativity, Theory of Gravitational Pull, and other established scientific theories).

Three Basic Postulates

- The existence of God.
- The existence of intellect and free will.
- The spirituality and immortality of the soul.

Four Postulates of Actions in Ethics

- There are actions which are right or wrong and good or bad.
- There are actions which man is obligated and not obligated to do.
- Man is responsible for his actions.
- Right actions are rewardable and wrong actions punishable.

LESSON 2: MORALITY AND THE HUMAN EXISTENCE AND KEY CONCEPTS

Man as the Sole Moral Agent

Moral Agent

- A person who can **discern right from wrong** and be held **accountable** for his/her actions; has an **ethical responsibility** not to cause **unjustified harm**.
- Traditionally assigned only to those who can be held **responsible for their actions**. Children and adults with certain mental disabilities may have little or no capacity to be moral agents.

Man is the only moral being because:

- Man is a being of action** – Man acts and knows his act.

- **Man has Intellect** – enables him to know what is right/wrong, good/bad.
- **Man has Will** – Man is free to act or not to act.

Intellect	Description	Will
Wisdom	Highest goal	Virtue
Truth	Goal	Good
Thinking	Function	Doing
Knowing	Purpose	Choosing

Moral and Non-Moral Standards

Moral Standard

- **Norms** – general rules about our actions or behaviors.
- **Values** – enduring beliefs/statements about what is good and desirable or not.
- **Moral standards** = norms individuals/groups have about actions believed to be **morally right or wrong**, plus the values placed on what's morally good/bad. (Norms + Values = Moral Standard)

Non-Moral Standard

Rules **unrelated to moral or ethical considerations** – e.g., rules of etiquette, fashion standards, rules in games, house rules.

Six Characteristics of Moral Standards

- 1 Involve serious wrongs or significant benefits.
- 2 Ought to be preferred to other values.
- 3 Not established by authority figures.
- 4 Have the trait of universalizability.
- 5 Based on impartial considerations.
- 6 Associated with special emotions and vocabulary.

Rules

Rules are specifically defined as:

- Instructions that tell you what you are allowed / not allowed to do.
- Statements telling people what they should do to achieve success or a benefit.
- Statements describing the way things usually happen in a particular situation.
- Telling the normal state of affairs; may influence or restrict actions.
- Something officially decided as true or should happen by an authority.
- Principles or regulations governing conduct, action, procedure, arrangement, etc.

The Usual Rules of Lives

- **Etiquette** – judge manners good/bad; dictated by socio-economic elite.
- **Legal** – judge legal right/wrong; formulated by representatives of the people.
- **Language** – judge grammatically right/wrong; evolve through use.
- **Aesthetics** – judge good/bad art; dictated by art connoisseurs.
- **Athletic** – judge how well a game is played; formulated by governing bodies.

Rules are important because:

- Prudent laws are the foundations of a nation.
- Laws organize our lives.
- Rules help us get along together and show respect.

- Rules organize relations between individuals and societies.
- Rules make the world a peaceful place to live.
- Rules serve as a balance between laws and rights.

Ethical Dilemma and Critical Thinking

- **Dilemma** – a situation forcing a choice between two or more conflicting options, none acceptable.
- **Ethical/moral dilemmas** – dilemmas involving human actions with moral implications.
- **Moral dilemmas** – "moral agents" forced to choose between conflicting options, none morally acceptable.

Sample Case: Maria, deeply religious, has an ectopic pregnancy that endangers her life. Continuing risks her death; aborting saves her but implies killing the fetus — a moral principle is compromised either way.

3 Conditions for Moral Dilemmas

- 1 The agent is obliged to decide which course of action is best.
- 2 There must be different courses of action to choose from.
- 3 Whatever course is taken, some moral principle is always compromised.

How to Solve an Ethical Dilemma

- **Refute the paradox** – analyze; the dilemma may be logically refuted.
- **Value theory approach** – choose the greater good or lesser evil.
- **Find alternative solutions** – reconsider the problem for new options.

Critical Thinking

The process by which we determine whether something is **right or wrong** – a form of analysis distinguishing fact vs. fiction and identifying the unknown, enabling decisions based on truths and verified information.

Reason and Impartiality

- **Equal treatment** of all rivals/disputants; mediator/judge must be fair.
- Example: entries submitted under pseudonym to ensure impartiality.
- Every **stakeholder's interests** should be considered.
- **One must not be arbitrary.**
- Treat everyone the same unless there is **good reason not to.**

Foundation of Moral Principle

- **Principle** – from Latin "**princeps**," "a source or beginning"; that on which something is **based, founded, originated, or initiated.**
- A **foundational moral principle** is the **universal norm** upon which all other principles on rightness/wrongness are based – the **source of morality.** It is contained in the **natural law.**

Natural Law

- "It is the law written in the hearts of men." (Romans 2:15)
- St. Thomas: "the light of natural reason, whereby we discern what is good and what is evil... an imprint on us of the divine light..." (A. Panizo)

Freedom

- Freedom is **human's greatest quality**, a reflection of our Creator.
- The power rooted in **reason and will**, to act or not act, performing deliberate actions on one's responsibility.
- "Having freedom means having **responsibility.**"

- **External Freedom** – free from outside factors limiting free will.
- **Internal Freedom** – free from interior factors limiting free will.
- **True Freedom** – always oriented toward the good; not the possibility of doing evil.

Relation Between Ethics and Beliefs

Ethics	Religious Belief
Asks fundamental questions of how human beings should live; what goals/values to strive for; what is right or wrong, virtuous and wicked.	Gives meaning to people's lives; professes existence and ultimate supremacy of a spiritual, supernatural, sacred, or divine realm transcending material day-to-day reality.

LESSON 3: ELEMENTS OF MORAL AGENT

Training of the Intellect

- To seek the purpose and time end of life.
- To grasp universal truths.
- To understand and reason out truths and moral precepts and relate them to life.
- To make judgements based on an objective standard of morality.
- To analyze the cause and effect of decisions and behavior.
- To solve problems critically and rationally.

Formation of the Will

- To love the Supreme Being and neighbor.
- To choose the higher good/universal truths and moral values.
- To act upon a decision.
- To take the rational and logical consequences of a decision and act.
- To make responsible use of freedom.

Culture (Provider of Moral Behavior)

- **Culture** – from Latin "**cultus**," meaning "**care**."
- Allan G. Johnson: culture is **the sum of symbols, ideas, forms of experience, and material products** associated with a social system.
- A **social heritage** of a society transmitted from one generation to the next through language.

Two Types of Culture

- 1 **Material Culture** – concrete/tangible things man creates and uses. (*Dwelling units, tools, weapons, clothing, books, machines, artifacts, relics, fossils*)
- 2 **Non-Material Culture** – intangible objects a person uses, follows, professes, conforms to. (*Knowledge, laws, lifestyle, teachings, ideas, customs, moral behavior, mores, values, language, sanctions*)

Providers of Moral Behavior in a Culture

- The Family
- The School
- The Church
- The Government
- The Workplace

Cultural Relativism

The idea that a person's beliefs, values, and practices **should be understood based on the person's own culture** rather than judged against the criteria of another culture.

Strengths

- Promotes cooperation.
- Creates a society where equality is possible.
- People can pursue a genuine interest.
- Encourages respect.
- Preserves human cultures.
- Creates a society without judgment.
- Moral relativism can be excluded from it.
- Personal moral codes based on societal standards, made easy.
- Stops cultural conditioning.

Weaknesses

- Fueled by personal bias.
- Would create chaos.
- Based on the perfection of humanity.
- Could promote a lack of diversity.
- Draws people away from one another.
- Could limit moral progress.
- Could limit humanity's progress.
- Can turn perceptions into truths.

Universal Values

A value is universal when it has the **same value for all, same worth for all** or for almost all people.

Two Ways to Understand Universal Values

- 1 When everybody finds it valuable.
- 2 When all people have reason to believe it has value.

Shalom Schwartz (2014) proposed ten broad, universal, fairly comprehensive value domains:

Ten Values

- 1 Self-Direction
- 2 Stimulation
- 3 Hedonism
- 4 Achievement
- 5 Power
- 6 Security
- 7 Conformity
- 8 Tradition
- 9 Benevolence
- 10 Universalism

QUICK-REVIEW SUMMARY

Concept	Key Point
Ethics	Branch of philosophy on right/wrong, good/bad, fair/unfair
Morality	Character/behavior/custom; relation of human activity to reason
Three Epochs	Cosmocentric → Theocentric → Anthropocentric
Human Acts	Free, knowing, voluntary
Acts of Man	No knowledge, no consent, involuntary
Branches of Moral Phil.	Meta-Ethics, Normative Ethics, Applied Ethics
Basic Postulates	God, Intellect & Free Will, Immortality of Soul
Moral Agent	Discerns right from wrong; accountable
Moral Standard	Norms + Values
Non-Moral Standard	Etiquette, fashion, games, house rules

Moral Dilemma	Forced choice between conflicting options, none fully acceptable
Foundational Moral Principle	Natural law
Culture	Social heritage – material and non-material
Cultural Relativism	Judge morals within their own cultural context
Universal Values	Same worth for all people (Schwartz's 10 values)